

AFRICA: LOCATION, PHYSICAL FEATURES & WILDLIFE

Quick Revision & Exam Preparation Guide

QUICK REVISION HIGHLIGHTS:

- **Size & Position:** 2nd largest continent; lies between 37°N–35°S latitude & 17°W–51°E longitude.
- **Unique Distinction:** Only continent crossed by Equator, Tropic of Cancer, Tropic of Capricorn, & Prime Meridian.
- **Highest Peak:** Mt Kilimanjaro (5,895m) — an extinct volcano in the Ethiopian Highlands region.
- **Major Water Bodies:** Longest river = Nile; largest lake = Lake Victoria; largest desert = Sahara Desert.
- **Rift Valley:** Great Rift Valley stretches ~8,000 km from Lake Malawi to Red Sea & Dead Sea.

1. Location, Extent & Geographic Boundaries

Africa is the **second-largest continent** in the world, located south of Europe and south-west of Asia. Most of Africa lies within the **tropical region** (between Tropic of Cancer and Tropic of Capricorn). The Equator divides Africa into two unequal parts, with the larger landmass in the Northern Hemisphere.

Geographic Boundary / Feature	Details & Connecting Water Bodies
Latitudinal Extent	37°N latitude in the north to 35°S latitude in the south
Longitudinal Extent	17°W longitude in the west to 51°E longitude in the east
Northern Boundary	Mediterranean Sea (separates Africa from Europe; touches at Strait of Gibraltar)
North-Eastern Boundary	Red Sea & Isthmus of Suez / Strait of Bab-el-Mandeb (separates Africa from Asia)
Eastern & Western Boundaries	Indian Ocean to the East; Atlantic Ocean to the West

2. Major Physical Features

A. Mountains & Highlands

- **Atlas Mountains:** Located in north-western Africa. Young fold mountains comprising three parallel ranges.
- **Ethiopian Highlands:** Eastern Africa (volcanic origin). Contains **Mt Kilimanjaro (5,895 m)**, an extinct volcano and Africa's highest peak. Other notable peaks: Mt Kenya, Mt Rwenzori, Mt Elgon.
- **Drakensberg Mountains:** Located along south-eastern coast. Young fold mountains forming steep edge of vast plateau.

B. Plateaus, Plains & Deserts

- **Plateaus & Karoo:** Almost entire continent is a huge plateau of old volcanic rocks. *Karoo Plateau* lies west of Drakensberg. Low central plateaus stretch from Atlantic Ocean to Nile Valley (includes *Ahaggar & Tibesti* Mountains).
- **Plains:** Coastal plains are narrow. The low-lying *Congo River Basin* is the main interior plain region.
- **Deserts:** **Sahara Desert** (north) is the world's largest hot desert (spread across 11 countries). Southern deserts include the coastal **Namib Desert** and interior **Kalahari Desert**.

C. The Great Rift Valley

The **Great Rift Valley** extends ~8,000 km from Lake Malawi to the Red Sea, Gulf of Suez, Gulf of Aqaba, and Dead Sea (Asia). Split into two arms containing rift lakes: *Tanganyika, Malawi, Albert, Edward, Kivu, Rukwa, Turkana*. **Lake Victoria** sits between the two arms.

3. Major Rivers & Lakes of Africa

River	Length Rank & Course	Key Characteristics & Landmarks
Nile River	Longest river in the world. Flows north into Mediterranean Sea.	Formed by confluence of White Nile and Blue Nile at Khartoum. Source of White Nile is <i>Lake Victoria</i> . Never dries up.
Congo River	2nd longest in Africa. Flows through west-central Africa.	Called ' <i>Highway of Central Africa</i> '. Carries largest water volume. Features Livingstone Falls, Inga Falls, Boyoma Falls.
Niger River	3rd longest in Africa. Flows through 4 countries.	Flows through Guinea, Mali, Niger, and Nigeria into Gulf of Guinea.
Zambezi River	4th longest in Africa. Drains into Indian Ocean.	Drains southern Africa. Site of world-famous Victoria Falls and human-made Lake Kariba.

Important Lakes: **Lake Victoria** (largest lake in Africa, source of White Nile); **Lake Chad** (freshwater lake south of Sahara); **Lake Nasser** (behind Aswan Dam on River Nile) and **Lake Kariba** (on Zambezi) are major human-made lakes.

4. Wildlife & Popular Safari Destinations

Africa boasts unequalled wildlife diversity. Primary national park attractions feature the '**Big Five**': *Lion, Leopard, Rhinoceros, Elephant, and Cape Buffalo*.

National Park / Reserve	Country	Key Wildlife & Ecological Significance
Serengeti National Park	Tanzania	Famous for the massive annual migration of wildebeest and zebra.
Masai Mara National Reserve	Kenya	Witnesses annual migration of wildebeest and zebra.
Kruger National Park	South Africa	Greatest variety of wildlife, including all members of the 'Big Five'.
Etosha National Park	Namibia	Large populations of African elephants and black rhinoceros.
Bwindi Impenetrable NP	Uganda	Large chimpanzee and mountain gorilla populations.
Chobe National Park	Botswana	Supports a large African elephant population.
Hwange National Park	Zimbabwe	Supports large populations of wild dogs, giraffes, lions, and elephants.
South Luangwa National Park	Zambia	Famous for lions, hippos, and abundant bird species diversity.

5. Key Terms & Historic Exploration

IMPORTANT REVISION DEFINITIONS & HISTORIC NOTES:

- **Tropical Region:** The geographic zone lying between Tropic of Cancer (23.5°N) and Tropic of Capricorn (23.5°S).
- **Extinct Volcano:** A volcano that has not erupted for hundreds of years and shows no possibility of future eruption (e.g., Mt Kilimanjaro).
- **David Livingstone (1813–1873):** Scottish explorer who crossed Kalahari Desert, explored Zambezi river, made transcontinental journey from Atlantic to Indian Ocean, and discovered Victoria Falls as well as Lakes Ngami, Malawi, and Bangweulu.